ORIGINAL SIGNALS: ETHICS AND EXPERIMENTATION IN THE POST HUMAN PRESENT

Paul Chambers
School of Social Sciences
The University of Adelaide

ABSTRACT

This is an anthropological report into the practice of contemporary computer music production. Its purpose is to describe how and why the computer has become so central in the creative lives of its users. It differs from other studies into computer music in that it is concerned with a wide variety of experience and aesthetics. The paper draws upon a 12-month-long ethnography into electronic music practice in Adelaide, based on participant observation and in-depth semi-structured interviews. The research has covered over 60 events, and interviews with over 50 musicians, aiming for a broad spectrum of participants based on age, genre, gender, and experience. Questions explored the practice, values and beliefs of those currently engaged in electronic music production, and the role of digital technology in self- representation around music. By focusing on a demographic attuned to current trends through participation in a competitive cultural industry, combined with the experimentation that is a part of finding one's own creative expression, it was hoped this social group would be ideal for accessing contemporary attitudes to our relationship with technology.

This paper has two aims. First, it shows how aesthetic performance seeks to accommodate a highly individualistic ethical attitude. In her ethnography of cultural production at the BBC1, musician and anthropologist Georgia Born, identified how the aesthetics of performance always reflect the ethical orientation of the producer2. Against a background of global influences, local contexts and media infrastructures, where the center of the action is increasingly open to question, the infinite possibilities of digital technology are attractive for the expression of a complex contemporary subjectivity of interaction and relationality.

Secondly it presents three case studies that illustrate how the accessibility of musical experimentation afforded by the computer can synthesize personal development with virtual possibilities. With social media a live feed of what is happening culturally throughout the world, my participants input from a spectrum of influences, transforming them through accessible software platforms, often producing works designed to reject comfortable classification.

An attitude of experimentation, allied to ethical values, characterizes this performance politics of the personal.

This paper also has a theoretical function, to test the claims of posthumanist writers, who champion a move away from the rigid definitions of human, nature and machine, into an altogether new assemblage where such boundaries become open to question. Rosi Braidotti envisions a new cosmopolitan humanism emerging3, "drawing energy from the thinkability of the future...an active transposition, a transformation at the in-depth level, a change of culture akin to genetic mutations, but registered also at the ethical level."4 The paper asks how computer music practice may act as an indicator of what we may be in the process of becoming?

REFERENCES

Born, G. 2002. "Reflexivity and Ambivalence: Culture, Creativity and Government in the BBC." Cultural Values, 6(1-2): 65-90

Braidotti, R. 2012. "Posthuman, All Too Human: Towards a New Process Ontology." Theory, Culture & Society, 23(7-8): 197-208.

Braidotti, R. 2013. The Posthuman. Cambridge & Malden: Polity Press.

Szczepanik, P. 2013. "On the Ethnography of Media Production: An Interview with Georgina Born." Iluminace, 25(3), 99-119.